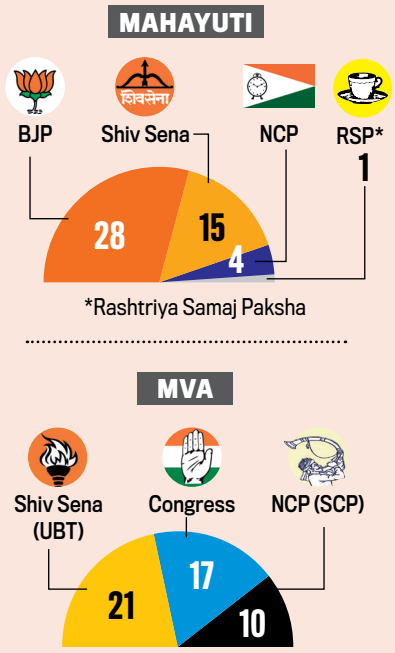
# A STATE OF W

## THEIR SHARE OF THE SEATS

Number of constituencies the parties are contesting of 48




## MAHAYUTI (NDA)

### STRENGTHS

- The TINA factor—there is no national alternative to Narendra Modi
- The defecting local satraps in its ranks
- Ample resources to compete in a five-phase election, including a last-mile connect
- The *labharthi* vote, especially that of senior citizens
- The NCP (Ajit Pawar) gets the support of most of the undivided party's sub-regional satraps and co-operative barons, who carry their voters with them

### WEAKNESSES

- Perception that the BJP split two regional parties using central probe agencies
- Rural and semi-urban distress, ferment among the youth over unaffordable education and lack of jobs
- The notion that the BJP has plateaued in the state
- Unease in the ranks of Shinde's legislative cohort as MLAs fear that they may be asked to make way for their BJP counterparts
- A section of the dominant Marathas are upset at the BJP

formidable army from Delhi was at the gates. The fight was existential. Between glory and the political graveyard.

## Broken Fortresses

Maratha forts are usually set atop steep cliffs immune to invasion, but here were two that had developed cracks in the ramparts—both Uddhav and Sharad Pawar have sustained grievous injury to their political estates. The source of their torment has been stalking the countryside too. Pune, Solapur, Karad, Malshiras, Osmanabad, Latur...Prime Minister Narendra Modi's compressed six rallies in just two days in the run-up to the third phase on May 7. In all, he has addressed 12 since campaigning began. The verbal artillery has gone through all the shades. On April 29, in Pune, Modi chose to describe Pawar Sr as a "*bhatakti aatma*", or a wandering spectre that has haunted Maharashtra politics for decades. The veteran retorted that the same Modi had once called him his guru, others speculated on which side such pointed rhetoric would benefit.

The reasons for the special attention Modi is bestowing on Maharashtra are clear: with its 48 Lok Sabha seats, it may well be the state that makes or breaks his quest for a comfortable majority. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) had won 41 of those seats in 2019. But most political thrillers pale before what happened next: the story started with a twist. The Shiv Sena, the oldest and most natural Hindutva ally of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), split off from it and formed a government at the head of an unlikely coalition with 'secular' parties. But it was a corkscrew of a plot that could only move forward in twists: in an infamous sequence of events, first the Sena was split in June 2022. A year later, the BJP's anxiety that Eknath Shinde would not be able to deliver the goods in the Lok Sabha election drove another split, this time in Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). Both the breakaway factions, sanctified with the party name and symbol, are now with the BJP, ruling Maharashtra in another unlikely coalition. Now the knife awaits its final twist.

This convoluted history means the two battle formations are eclectic collages woven out of expediency, not simple tribal loyalties. There's an uncle versus nephew pairing in Pawar Sr and the renegade Ajit Pawar, now deputy chief minister and part of Modi's phalanx on stage. There are cousins ranged against each other—Ajit versus his uncle's daughter and heir apparent Supriya Sule; even Uddhav versus Raj Thackeray, who honours the family tradition of not participating in elections but is backing the NDA. Sisters-in-law Supriya and Ajit's wife Sunetra are facing off in a fight for the old Pawar pocket borough Baramati. Not just kinsfolk, old fellow travellers